

Perceived Threats of DEI: Demystifying White American Opposition

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Introduction

Resistance to DEI policies limits its successful outcomes. Scholars have identified three relevant threats DEI may impose: a resource threat, a symbolic threat, and a morality threat (Iyer, 2022).

RQ1: Which threat is most implicated in opposition to DEI policy

RQ2: Do people treat the term “DEI” differently than instances of DEI policy

Method

Sample

White American Adults (N = 217)
Mean age = 41, 63.5% socially liberal

Experiment

Randomly assigned participants to a threat condition

They read a vignette meant to elicit one threat

Exploratory analyses were pre-planned

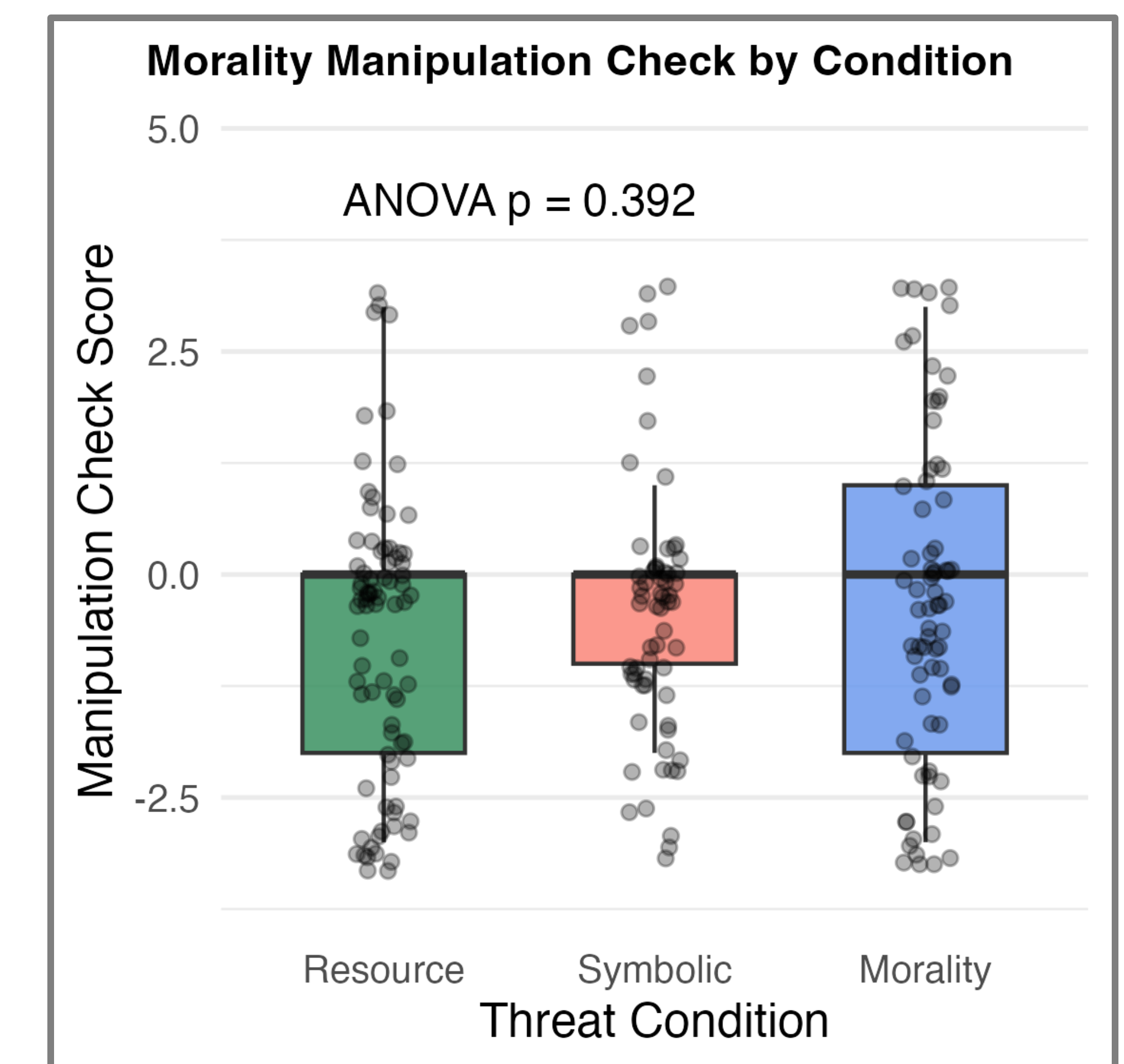
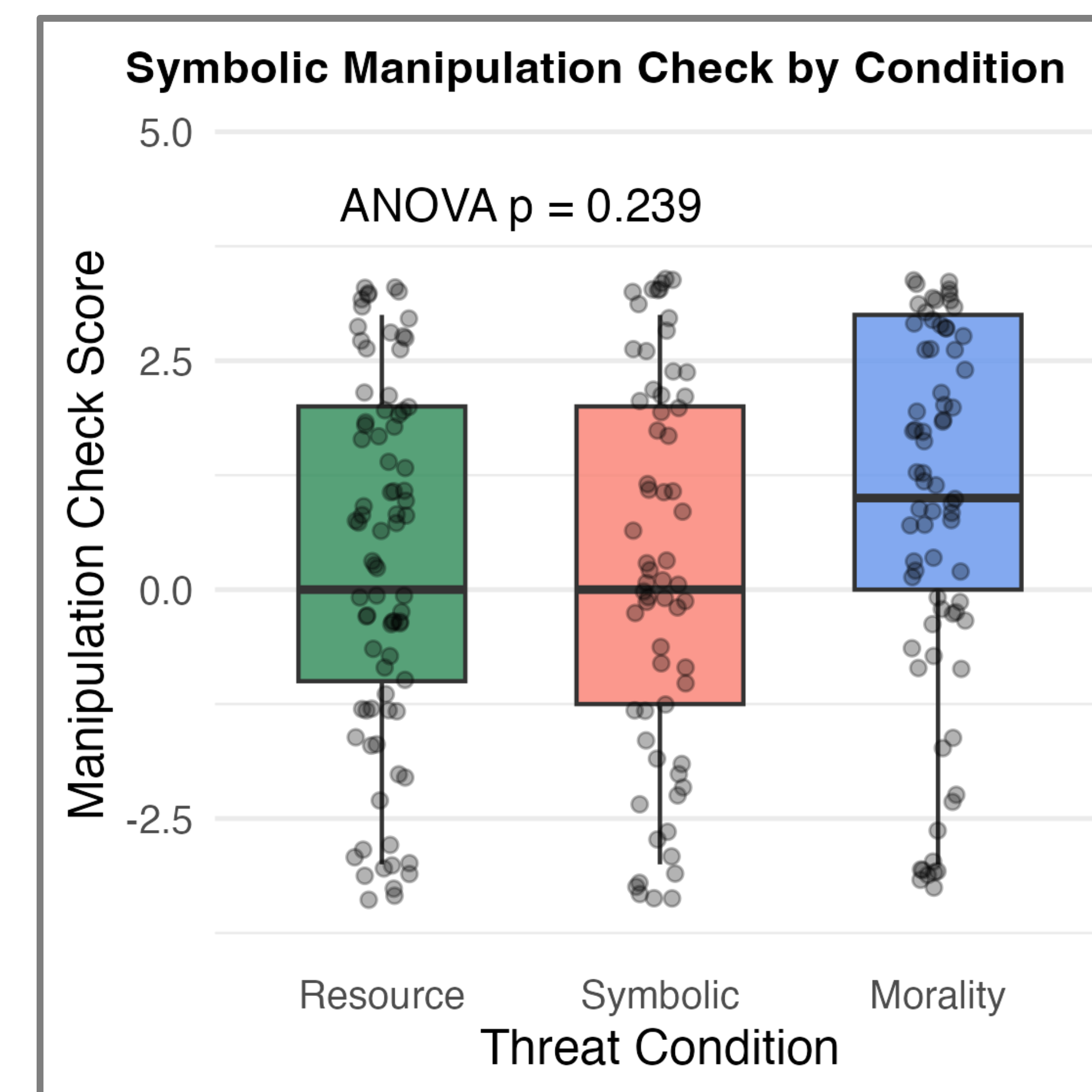
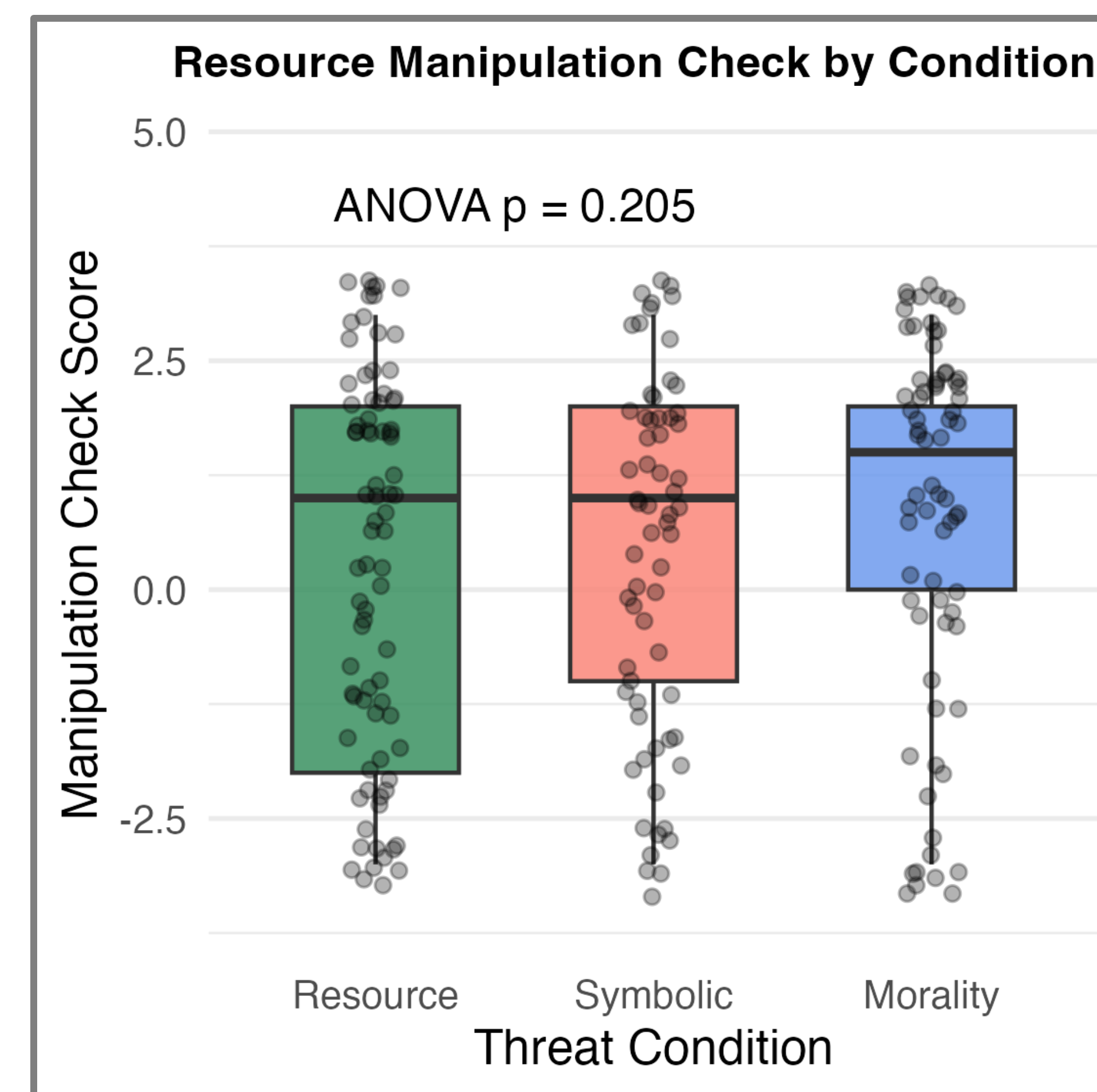
Takeaways

RQ1: We did not successfully manipulate threat perceptions. No differences between conditions on DEI support

RQ2: We found preliminary evidence that participants see DEI differently than its policies.

RQ3: Manipulations failed to alter perceptions of DEI due to polarized beliefs.

RQ1: Experimental Analyses



Experimental results led to RQ3: Why did the manipulations fail?

RQ2 & RQ3: Exploratory Analyses

Table 1: Predictors of DEI Attitudes Across Different Measures

	Dependent variable:				
	DEI (1)	SPT (2)	WPT (3)	TM (4)	DT (5)
Gender	0.305**	0.163	0.229	0.353*	0.717***
Age	-0.008	-0.008	-0.001	0.005	-0.020**
Social Conservatism	-0.224***	0.008	-0.148	-0.207**	-0.390***
Economic Conservatism	-0.047	-0.179*	-0.154	-0.048	0.074
Education	0.040	-0.004	0.125	0.001	0.079
Social Status	0.216***	0.248***	0.197*	0.401***	0.213**
White ID	-0.162**	0.057	-0.194*	-0.047	-0.071
National ID	0.071	0.032	0.295***	0.126	0.078
System Justifying Beliefs	-0.493***	-0.115	-0.554***	-0.715***	-0.549***
Observations	216	216	216	216	216
R ²	0.644	0.127	0.382	0.466	0.479
Adjusted R ²	0.628	0.089	0.355	0.443	0.456

Note: *p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001. The last four variables represent policy instances: Strong Preferential Treatment (SPT), Weak Preferential Treatment (WPT), Training & Mentoring (TM), and Diversity Training (DT).

